The Noble Dhāraṇī of the Six Gates

Āryaṣaṇmukhanāmadhāraṇī · Toh 916 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་སྒོ་དྲུག་པ་ཞེས་བྱ་བ་ཟུང་འཇུག

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Six Gates, known in Sanskrit as Ārya Ṣaṇmukha Nāma Dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phakpa Go Drukpa Zhejawé Zung, is a brief dhāraṇī text that opens with homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī. Its setting is an assembly courtyard adorned with the seven precious substances and suspended in the sky above the Pure Abodes, where the Buddha, surrounded by countless bodhisattvas, urges them to take up this dhāraṇī for the benefit and happiness of all beings. Rather than a string of mantra syllables, the dhāraṇī takes the form of a series of aspirations and vows, beginning with the wish that whatever suffering one meets while passing through the births of saṃsāra be understood in its true equality and dedicated toward the welfare of others. It is Toh 916 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the collection of dhāraṇī texts, and the same work is also preserved elsewhere in the canon among the general sūtras.

In the language of India: ārya ṣanmukha nāma dhāraṇī
In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Six Gates.

Homage to Mañjuśrī, the youthful one.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in the courtyard of his assembly, situated in the midst of the sky above the Pure Abodes and beautifully laid out and adorned with the seven kinds of precious substances. He was there together with countless hosts of bodhisattvas. At that time the Blessed One said to the bodhisattvas:

"Sons of noble family, for the benefit and happiness of all beings, take up the dhāraṇī called the Six Gates. It is as follows:

Whatever suffering I experience as I pass from saṃsāra into the other birthplaces of saṃsāra, may it never take on the character of not being known as equal to that of all sentient beings.

Whatever worldly happiness and prosperity I experience, may it be enjoyed in common with all sentient beings.

Whatever evil, nonvirtuous karma I have committed, may it not remain unconfessed, but be confessed one by one through unsurpassed confession.

Whatever deeds of Māra I have done, may they not remain unrecognized through unsurpassed full understanding.

Whatever roots of virtue I possess that are endowed with the perfections, whether mundane or supramundane, may they all become the fruit of unsurpassed wisdom.

Whatever liberation I possess, through it may all sentient beings be liberated.

May I abide neither in saṃsāra nor in nirvāṇa.

tadyathā oṃ kṣame kṣame kṣānte kṣānte dame dame dānte dānte bhadre bhadre subhadre subhadre candre candre sucandre sucandre candrakiraṇe candravati tejovati yaśovati dharmavati brahmavati sarvakleśaviśodhani sarvaarthasādhani sarvaarthapraśamani paramārthasādhani kāyaviśodhani bāgaviśvadhani manaḥsaṃśvadhani svāhā

Sons of noble family, thus, if any son or daughter of noble family recites this dhāraṇī called the Six Gates three times by day and three times by night, all of that person's karmic obscurations will be purified, and for up to seven lifetimes that person will remember their births. They will become fully and manifestly awakened into unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening."

When the Blessed One, delighted, had spoken thus, those hosts of bodhisattvas and those sons of the gods of the realm of the Pure Abodes rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

Here ends the Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Six Gates.

Translator's Notes

• The Tibetan repeats two phrases, "not confessed" and "mundane and," apparently by scribal duplication. Each has been translated once, since the repetition adds no sense. In the third aspiration the Tibetan literally reads "through unsurpassed individual confession, may it not remain not individually confessed." It is rendered here as a single positive wish.

Colophon

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spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.